HUMAN TRAFFICKING

MYTHS, FACTS, AND FUTURE ACTIONS



- Human trafficking often begins with an offer a person cannot refuse, like a good job or the chance to get married and create an independent life. But instead of what was promised, they find themselves trafficked and exploited.
- The most common forms of human trafficking are commercial sexual exploitation, forced labor, forced scamming, and forced marriage (including child marriage.)

United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) as:

"The recruitment, transportation, transfer, harbouring or receipt of people through force, fraud or deception, with the aim of exploiting them for profit."

Means

- Threats or use of force
- Coercion
- Fraud
- Deception
- Abuse of a position of vulnerability
- Giving payments or benefits
- Abduction

5 Types of Human Trafficking

- Exploitation in the entertainment, sex, and hospitality industries
- Domestic work
- Forced marriage
- Forced labor in factories, on construction sites, or in the agricultural sector

Without pay?

- Victims are forced to work without pay or with an inadequate salary, living in fear of violence and often in inhumane conditions.

6 WHEN DID HUMAN TRAFFICKING START?

- Human trafficking is not a modern invention. Forced labor, sexual exploitation, and the buying and selling of people have existed across cultures and centuries
- The 20th century saw the first serious international efforts to name and prohibit trafficking, including the 1949 UN Convention for the Suppression of the Traffic in Persons, followed decades later by the landmark Palermo Protocol in 2000
- Today, human trafficking is shaped by globalization, migration, conflict, and digital technology. Traffickers recruit online, and people move across borders with ease.

7 WHERE DOES HUMAN TRAFFICKING OCCUR?

- The Global Slavery Index documents modern slavery and human trafficking in every country on earth, including every wealthy Western nation.
- The highest absolute numbers are in Asia and the Pacific.
- Cambodia, Vietnam, Thailand, and Myanmar are among the regions where trafficking is most prevalent, driven by poverty, displacement, limited legal protections for migrant workers, and demand from both regional and international markets.

HUMAN TRAFFICKING IN GLOBAL SUPPLY CHAINS

- Clothing, electronics, seafood, cocoa, cotton are all industries with documented histories of forced and trafficked labor at various points in their supply chains.

9 How many people are affected by human trafficking?

According to the Global Slavery Index (Walk Free Foundation, 2023), approximately **50 million people** worldwide are living in modern slavery, which includes human trafficking. Of these, around 27.6 million are in forced labour and 6.3 million are in forced commercial sexual exploitation. Women and girls make up 71% of all trafficking survivors.

10 Look for clusters of indicators, and trust your instincts.

Signs in a person

- **Seems disoriented or confused** about their location, the date, or basic facts about themselves
- **Cannot speak freely** — is always accompanied by someone who speaks for them or monitors their answers
- **Appears coached** — gives scripted, rehearsed answers that don't feel natural
- **Shows signs of physical abuse,** malnourishment, exhaustion, or untreated injuries

- **Has few or no personal possessions** — no ID, no phone, no money of their own
- **Lives and works in the same place,** or is transported between locations by someone else
- **Seems fearful, anxious, or submissive,** especially around a particular person
- **Is a minor** who appears to be engaged in commercial sex or who has an older ‘boyfriend’ or ‘manager’
- **Has tattoos or branding** that may indicate ownership — though this is not universal

Signs in a situation

- **Multiple people living in a cramped space** with limited freedom of movement
- **Someone else holds or controls their identity documents** — passport, visa, ID
- **They are not allowed to speak for themselves** in a medical, legal, or official setting
- **Their story changes** or doesn't match the documentation
- **They are unaware of their employer's address** or the terms of their employment

WHEN SMUGGLING TURNS INTO TRAFFICKING

- Sometimes, people **start as smuggled migrants** but later become **trafficking victims**.
- This happens when they fall into **debt bondage, unsafe work, or are threatened into doing things** they didn't agree to.
- Even if someone **consents at first**, that doesn't mean they are safe.
- Once in a foreign place, they may have **no choice but to obey** due to **fear, debt, or abuse** (Andrees, 2008; Herman, 2006).

CRUEL OFFENDERS VS. HELPLESS VICTIMS

- In public debates, **human trafficking** and **smuggling** are often shown as a story of **evil criminals** versus **powerless victims**.
- Events like the **Dover lorry deaths (2000)** and the **Golden Venture shipwreck (1993)** shaped how people and media view these crimes.
- The reality of smuggling is often more **complex** and involves **consent** between **migrants** and **smugglers**, who may be **family or friends** — not always criminal masterminds.
- Migration is not always a solo decision. It's often supported by **migrant networks** — groups of family and friends who help with **information, contacts, and planning**. This is known as **"chain migration"** and is driven by both **push and pull factors**.

WHO ARE THE SMUGGLERS?

- In many cases, **smugglers and migrants come from the same background**.
- Studies in the Netherlands show that smugglers often have **ties to both home and destination countries** (Kleemans & van de Bunt, 2003).
- Surprisingly, some smugglers were once **smuggled migrants** themselves.
- They use their **experience and connections** to help others — often for money, but not always as masterminds.

HOW SMUGGLING NETWORKS WORK

- Smuggling networks are often **small and flexible**.
- They include people at every stage: origin, transit, and destination. These networks may use **forged documents**, making travel easier — like by **airplane**.
- Without documents, the journey is **longer and riskier**.
- Migrants rely on **local contacts**
- The process involves more **transfers, stops**, and **coordination**. Sometimes a **chain of loosely connected groups** handles the journey from start to finish (Zhang, 2007; Neske & Doomernik, 2006).

IS HUMAN SMUGGLING CONTROLLED BY ORGANIZED CRIME?

- There is an ongoing debate about the role of **organized crime** in **human smuggling**, especially in the case of **Chinese migrants**.
- Studies using **law enforcement data** show a **wider range** of organizational types. For example, **Soudijn (2006)** studied **88 Dutch court cases** and found that not all smugglers were **Chinese**—about **25%** were of other ethnicities.
- These smuggling groups **take contracts** from different sources and work with **foreign partners**.
- While they may not be tightly controlled, they often form **stable alliances** and have **consistent group members** when the smuggling is running smoothly.

WHO?

- Countries with **high corruption** also see more trafficking cases.
- Studies show a strong link between **corruption and trafficking** (Bales, 2005; Studnicka, 2010).
- In Brazil, **71%** of trafficking cases involved corrupt officials.

THE TRAFFICKING PROCESS – 3 MAIN STAGES

Trafficking usually follows three stages:

1. **Recruitment**,
2. **Transportation**,
3. **Exploitation**.

Victims are often recruited with **false job promises** in hotels, cleaning, or entertainment. Many knowingly agree to **work in prostitution**, but often **don't know the real conditions** (Vocks & Nijboer, 1999).

TRAVEL AND ENTRY INTO DESTINATION COUNTRIES

- Victims often **cross borders legally** with **real documents**, using **student, tourist, or business visas**
- This makes it hard for **border officers to identify** them as victims.
- In the Netherlands, many trafficked women were found in **brothels** or **window prostitution**.
- Some clubs were **owned by traffickers**, some **cooperated**, and others simply **looked the other way**.

Bangladesh in the Trafficking Landscape

A Source, Transit, and Destination Country

Source Country → **Transit Route** → **Destination Country**

Key Drivers

- **Unsafe and irregular migration pathways**
- **Poverty and widespread unemployment**
- **Natural disasters and displacement**
- **Organized criminal networks exploiting vulnerability**

Trafficking in Bangladesh occurs through both cross-border movement and internal exploitation, affecting men, women, and children across urban, rural, and migration settings.

Currently, seven major international destinations are active for human trafficking via air routes. These include Italy, Serbia/Macedonia, Russia, the USA, Canada, Australia, and Cambodia/Laos.

Initially, visas for tourism, education, or employment are obtained. Subsequently, the individuals are transported to their final destination via a third country to evade direct surveillance by the destination country.

- For those heading to the United States, attempts are made to cross the border by traveling from Bangladesh to Brazil first, and then through Mexico.
- Individuals are first taken from Bangladesh to a third country—such as Nepal—and subsequently sent to Canada.

The route to Italy is currently one of the most complex and lengthy ones. Traffickers first send migrants from Bangladesh to the Middle East via Nepal, India, or Sri Lanka; the journey then proceeds through Egypt, Tunisia, or Libya before finally reaching Italy.

On the route to Australia, attempts are made to enter via sea, traveling from Bangladesh to Malaysia and subsequently to Indonesia.

The CID has provided information regarding a route to Russia that passes through Saudi Arabia.

The CID has also identified two major routes for maritime human trafficking. The first route involves transporting individuals from Bangladesh to Malaysia, and subsequently to Australia via Indonesia.

Under the second route, victims are trafficked from Bangladesh into Malaysia via Myanmar and Thailand.

Although the law on human trafficking mandates framing charges within 90 working days and concluding the trial within 180 working days, trials cannot be completed due to slow investigations.

Bangladeshis are most frequently trafficked to India, Malaysia, Thailand, Greece, Italy, Cyprus, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Oman, Iraq, Bahrain, and Libya.

The existing law for the prevention and suppression of human trafficking is not being enforced due to settlements reached in exchange for money. Yet, the law stipulates penalties—including the death penalty, life imprisonment, and a minimum of seven years in prison along with a fine of at least Tk 5 lakh—for organized human trafficking. Because traffickers evade punishment, they become emboldened and subsequently engage in human trafficking again.

He was sold to a cyber scam compound in exchange for money.

Between January and April of this year, 2,408 Bangladeshis traveled to Cambodia. However, the relevant authorities do not have information regarding how many of them fell victim to human trafficking and were sold in that country.

In 2025, more than 15,000 Bangladeshis traveled to Cambodia with clearance from the BMET.

Bangladesh does not have an embassy in Cambodia. Victims have alleged a lack of cooperation from the Cambodian embassy in Bangkok, which handles matters related to the country.

According to the latest Henley & Partners index, holders of Bangladeshi passports can currently travel to 36 countries worldwide without a prior visa.

(Electronic visa) or visa-on-arrival can be easily obtained online for a cost of just $30–$36. This tourist visa, costing approximately 3,600 Taka, allows for a stay of at least 30 days in Cambodia.

The Myanmar military recently conducted an operation in the Shwe Kokko area—a region known as an epicenter for human trafficking. As fierce clashes erupted between the military and ethnic rebels during the operation, thousands of people fled their homes and crossed into Thailand.

WHY IT'S HARD TO ESCAPE

Victims often stay due to:

- **Emotional ties**,
- **Fear of LEA**
- **Lack of better options**,
- **Shame or stigma**.

- **Free will** becomes a **blurred concept** in trafficking
- Many victims believe they **chose** this life, even when they are **controlled and abused**

Prevention and Response

- **Strengthen** child protection systems and early identification of victims
- **Enhance** cybercrime monitoring and digital safety education
- **Promote** school- and community-based awareness programmes
- **Ensure** victim-centred rehabilitation, psychosocial support, and access to justice
- **Improve** coordination among law enforcement, social services, NGOs, and child rights organizations

Media, Culture and Political Commitment

- **Utilize** television, radio, newspapers, social media, and folk theatre to raise awareness
- **Ensure** strong political commitment through effective policy implementation
- **Promote** integrity and accountability, with zero tolerance for corruption

POLICY MEASURES AND INTERVENTIONS

- One common way to fight **human trafficking** is through **stricter border control**. This means building **fences**, adding **security**, and targeting **physical smuggling routes**.
- But this strategy has **serious limitations**.
- Most **trafficking for sexual exploitation** happens **over short distances**, and many victims **travel voluntarily** at first — only to face **exploitation later**.
- Strict border control can have **dangerous side effects**. On the **US–Mexico border**, many migrants now face **deadly travel routes**.
- Research shows that since **2000**, over **300 migrant deaths per year** are recorded there. Many others are likely **never found** (Guerette, 2007).

HARM REDUCTION STRATEGIES

To reduce the dangers, some **proactive strategies** were introduced:

- **Educational campaigns** to warn migrants of risks
- **Training and life-saving equipment** for border agents
- **Search and rescue teams**
- **Lateral repatriation** – returning migrants to safer border areas

These efforts have **saved lives**, even if the **overall death rate** hasn't dropped significantly (Guerette, 2007).

ROLE OF TRANSIT COUNTRIES

Transit countries — where migrants pass through — also play a big role in stopping trafficking (Perrin, 2010).

They should:

- **Check travel documents**
- **Spot high-risk individuals**
- **Protect potential victims**
- **Prosecute traffickers**

But this is hard because many **victims travel with legal documents**, and may not even **know they're being trafficked** yet.

THE SWEDISH MODEL – CRIMINALIZING BUYERS

- In **Sweden**, prostitution is seen as **male violence against women**. Since **1999**
- This aims to **change social norms** and reduce demand.
- Studies show **street prostitution dropped** (Statens Offentliga Utredningar, 2010).
- However, **indoor and online sex work** has grown.

THE DUTCH MODEL – LEGALIZATION OF BROTHELS

- In **the Netherlands**, the **ban on brothels was lifted in 2000**. Voluntary prostitution by adults is legal under **strict licensing**.
- **Fewer undocumented prostitutes**
- But problems remain. Many women still work with **pimps**, and trafficking still happens behind **legal façades** (Daalder, 2007).

FINLAND'S MIXED MODEL

- **Finland** prohibits vulgarity **only if the person is trafficked or exploited**.
- But this raises an issue: **How can clients know?**
- Some clients do report suspicious cases.
- Campaigns like **"Appearances Are Deceptive"** in the Netherlands encourage this (Daalder, 2007).
- Yet, most men **don't take action**, even when they **suspect exploitation** (Farley et al., 2009).

BARRIERS TO LAW ENFORCEMENT

- Authorities often **focus on business owners**, but many **exploiters are pimps** who operate outside the legal system.
- Laws may discourage **open abuse**, but **hidden exploitation** continues in **homes, escort services**, or **online spaces**.
- Traffickers use **manipulation**, **debt**, and **emotional control** to silence victims.

LAW ENFORCEMENT GAPS

- In many regions, **authorities don't prioritize trafficking**.
- A U.S. survey showed that less than **10% of police agencies** identified any trafficking cases between 2000–2006 (Farrell et al., 2010).
- Also, **some countries mix up data** on **trafficking, smuggling**, and **illegal immigration**, making numbers **inaccurate or incomparable** (Bureau NRM, 2007).

THE PROBLEM WITH DEFINITIONS

While most countries accept the **UN definition of trafficking**, they **apply it differently**.

Differences arise in areas like:

- **Consent**
- **Cross-border movement**
- **Types of exploitation covered**

This leads to **"the never-ending story of a definition"** and unreliable statistics (Di Nicola, 2007).

LACK OF EVALUATION IN ANTI-TRAFFICKING PROJECTS

- Many **anti-trafficking programs** lack proper **monitoring and evaluation**.
- For example, in a review of 23 U.S.-funded projects abroad, only **10 measured performance**, and **none used strong scientific methods** (GAO, 2007; van der Laan et al., 2010).
- Without this, it's hard to know **what really works**.

NEW INITIATIVES FOR BETTER DATA

Several international projects now aim to **standardize trafficking data**, including:

- **Siamsect Project** (EU-funded): Developed a uniform template but was never implemented

- **IOM-Austria Project** (2007): Created **17 guidelines** for collecting comparable data (Aronowitz, 2009)

- **ICMPD** (International Centre for Migration Policy Development) **Project**: Built national databases tailored to **each country's laws and needs** (Surtees, 2007)

NEED FOR BETTER RESEARCH

Despite growing attention, **solid research is lacking**. We need to study:

- The **impact of immigration policies**
- The **costs, profits**, and **networks** behind smuggling and trafficking
- **Unintended side effects** on refugees and migrants

Most discussions are **emotional** and **ideologically driven**, especially around **sexual exploitation** (Weitzer, 2010).

EFFECTIVENESS OF INTERVENTIONS

We still know **too little** about what **anti-trafficking policies actually work**.

Key questions include:

- Which programs **protect victims**?
- Which methods **prosecute traffickers effectively**?
- Are some policies even **harmful or counterproductive**? (Dottridge, 2007)

Different Laws

National and International laws:

1. **The constitution of the people's Republic of Bangladesh**
2. **The prevention and Suppression of Human Trafficking Act 2012**
3. **Manob Pachar Tohobil Act 2017**
4. **The Prevention and Suppression of Human Trafficking Rules, 2017**
5. **National Anti-Human Trafficking Authority Rules of 2017**
6. **United Nations Convention Against Transactional Organized Crime**
7. **Protocol to Prevent, Suppress and Punish Trafficking in Persons, Especially Women and children;**
8. **Protocol against the smuggling of migrants by Land, Sea and Air;**

- https://hagarusa.org/human-trafficking/?utm_source=google&utm_medium=cpc&utm_campaign=21999292247&utm_content=&utm_term=&sg=GE0126WB2&gad_source=1&gad_campaignid=22458081798&gbraid=0AAAADptnLTGaJRv0auUYFRzllGeUE42U&gclid=CjwKCAjwy5rUBhB5EiwAIoAtCqR_6ml8D7cCTBG6Y5Lp37oHIVdtqUbkW5gZlfal2BE4dcQqpXXcxRoC8fYQAvD_BwE